

Checklist C: Authority Drift Tracker

1. Purpose and Scope

This instrument measures Authority Drift (AD), defined as the proportion of critical actions taken by participants operating outside their predefined role scope during a simulation. Authority Drift captures the erosion of organisational role boundaries under incident pressure, which is a diagnostic indicator of brittle governance structures and a systemic explanation for deficiencies in IRRS coordination and decision flow sub-metrics.

Authority Drift is not inherently negative in every instance. Isolated, justified cross-role actions may reflect appropriate adaptability. However, persistent or repeated drift indicates that formal response plans are being abandoned in favour of individual improvisation, which typically undermines accountability, disrupts coordinated action, and leaves strategic risk unmanaged.

This instrument informs the following IRRS sub-metrics: Role clarity, Decision flow, and Escalation path followed.

2. Pre-Simulation Requirement

Critical: Authority Drift cannot be assessed retrospectively without a documented baseline. All participants must have their designated roles and pre-declared scope of authority recorded in the Role Registry below before the simulation begins. Do not commence the simulation until this table is complete.

Complete the Role Registry in collaboration with the simulation facilitator and the organisation's incident response plan (IRP). The scope of authority column should reflect what each role is authorised to do independently, without requiring approval from another role.

Participant Identifier	Designated Role	Pre-Declared Scope of Authority (actions this role is authorised to take independently)

3. Pre-Simulation Setup

Organisation / Team	
Simulation Date	
Scenario Class	<i>Ransomware / Insider Threat / Cloud Misconfiguration / Credential Leakage (circle one)</i>
SRI Level	<i>1 / 2 / 3 / 4 / 5 (circle one)</i>
Evaluator Name	

4. Drift Type Classification

Before recording actions, familiarise yourself with the three drift classifications below. Record the drift type for each critical action observed during the simulation.

Drift Type	Direction	Description and Typical Governance Implication
Downwards Drift	Strategic to Technical	Senior leaders or managers perform technical actions that fall within the authorised scope of technical staff. Common examples include executives accessing security tooling, modifying configurations, or issuing containment commands directly. This pattern frequently disrupts technical workflows, introduces configuration inconsistencies, and leaves strategic oversight unattended.
Upwards Drift	Technical to Strategic	Technical staff assume strategic or governance decisions that fall outside their authorised scope, such as communicating externally with regulators, legal counsel, or media without executive authorisation, or making risk acceptance decisions that carry organisational liability. This pattern frequently creates external disclosure risk and undermines accountability.
No Drift	Within role boundary	The action was taken by a participant operating within their pre-declared role scope. Record as Y in the In Scope column and None in the Drift Type column.

Repeated drift events carry greater diagnostic weight than isolated occurrences. A single out-of-scope action under extreme pressure may reflect appropriate adaptability. A pattern of repeated drift across multiple actions indicates a structural governance problem requiring targeted remediation.

5. Authority Drift Tracking Table

Record one row per critical action observed during the simulation. A critical action is one that materially affects incident trajectory, governance posture, or organisational risk exposure. Minor or purely mechanical actions such as opening a log file or navigating a dashboard do not qualify. For each action, assess whether it was taken by a participant operating within or outside their pre-declared role scope from the Role Registry in Section 2.

#	Participant ID	Observed Action	In Scope? (Y / N)	Drift Type (Up / Down / None)	Organisational Impact Observed
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					

Total critical actions (A total):	Out-of-scope actions (A out-of-scope):	AD% = (A out-of-scope / A total) x 100 = %
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6. Scenario Threshold Guidance

The following reference bands indicate when a calculated Authority Drift percentage should be considered acceptable, elevated, or critical within a given scenario class. Higher drift thresholds are applied to lower SRI scenarios because governance-sensitive incidents may involve a degree of appropriate cross-role consultation that does not constitute problematic drift.

Important: In ransomware scenarios (SRI 5), strict role adherence is critical to maintaining coordinated containment, and drift above 20% is likely to undermine accountability and delay decisive action. In insider threat scenarios (SRI 4), some cross-role consultation may be appropriate given the governance sensitivity of the incident, and the threshold for critical classification is therefore set higher. Always interpret AD values relative to the scenario class and SRI level recorded in Section 3. Downwards drift and upwards drift should be reported separately as they have distinct governance remediation implications.

Scenario Class	SRI	Acceptable	Elevated	Critical
Ransomware Propagation	SRI 5	Under 10%	10% to 20%	Over 20%
Insider Data Exfiltration	SRI 4	Under 15%	15% to 25%	Over 25%
Cloud Misconfiguration	SRI 3	Under 20%	20% to 30%	Over 30%
Credential Leakage	SRI 3	Under 20%	20% to 30%	Over 30%

7. Worked Example (Insider Threat, SRI 4)

The following completed example is drawn from the theoretical worked example presented in the IRRS paper. It illustrates how the tracking table is completed and how the threshold guidance is applied. Note that in the original paper the worked example records AD = 30% across 10 total critical actions with 3 out-of-scope actions. The example below uses a reduced action set for illustrative clarity while preserving the same diagnostic conclusions.

#	Participant ID	Observed Action	In Scope?	Drift Type	Organisational Impact
1	Analyst A	Disabled user session upon anomalous file access detection	Y	None	Pre-authorised action executed correctly within role boundary
2	Analyst A	Applied USB restriction following media usage confirmation	Y	None	Pre-authorised action executed correctly within role boundary
3	Senior Manager B	Directly accessed and modified DLP alert configuration settings	N	Down	Technical action reserved for analyst role; caused configuration inconsistency and temporary loss of alert visibility
4	Analyst A	Revoked cloud access token	Y	None	Pre-authorised action executed correctly within role boundary

		following confirmed exfiltration evidence			
5	Analyst B	Independently escalated incident to external legal counsel without managerial authorisation	N	Up	Governance action outside technical role boundary; created external disclosure risk without executive sign-off
6	Analyst A	Raised formal internal escalation to incident commander per IRP	Y	None	Correct escalation executed within role boundary
A total = 6 A out-of-scope = 2		AD = (2/6) x 100 = 33%	Classification: CRITICAL (SRI 4, Insider Threat) 1x Downwards Drift, 1x Upwards Drift		

In this example, 2 of 6 critical actions were taken outside predefined role boundaries, producing an AD of 33%. One instance of downwards drift (a manager performing a technical action) and one instance of upwards drift (a technical staff member making an external governance decision) were recorded. Both instances had materially adverse organisational consequences. This directly explains the low scores in Role clarity ($s_i = 4$, $w_i = 5$) and Decision flow ($s_i = 3$, $w_i = 5$) in the corresponding IRRS calculation, and confirms that governance remediation rather than technical training is the appropriate intervention.

8. Evaluator Guidance Notes

- The Role Registry must be completed before the simulation begins. If role scope is unclear or undocumented by the organisation, record this as a finding in its own right and note that drift assessment may be limited by the absence of a formal authority baseline.
- Only critical actions are tracked. Use the definition in Section 5 to determine what qualifies. When in doubt about whether an action is critical, include it and note the ambiguity in the Organisational Impact column.
- Record participant identifiers rather than names. This preserves the system-level focus of the instrument and avoids the appearance of individual performance assessment.
- Repeated drift events should be flagged explicitly in the evaluator summary. A single out-of-scope action may reflect appropriate pressure-driven adaptability. Three or more out-of-scope actions by the same participant type suggest a structural authority gap in the IRP.
- Downwards and upwards drift should be reported separately in any post-simulation feedback, as they require different organisational remediation responses.
- This instrument is designed for system-level diagnostic analysis only and must not be used to evaluate individual competence, judgement, or professional conduct.

This instrument is part of the IRRS Human-Centric Telemetry suite. It should be used alongside Checklist A (Decision Latency Capture Sheet) and Checklist B (Communication Entropy Tally Sheet) to provide a complete diagnostic picture of human-system interaction during the simulation.